Cornwallis: Born into an aristocratic family and educated at Eton and Cambridge, Cornwallis joined the army in 1757. Upon his father's death in 1762 he became Earl Cornwallis and entered the House of Lords, the upper house of Britain. His military action in the American War of Independence was praiseworthy, inflicting defeats on the American army in a few battles though finally he had to surrender his army at Yorktown. Despite this defeat, Cornwallis retained the confidence of successive British governments and continued to enjoy an active career. Knighted in 1786, he was appointed Governor General by the East India Company government in British India.



Cornwallis

Results

The immediate result of the war was America's independence. For the first time a colonial power was overthrown by the colonised, leading to the establishment of a republican government in the United States. The colonists wanted to get rid of the feudal inequalities of Europe and they succeeded. For many followers of the Enlightenment in Europe, the language of the Declaration of Independence seemed a living fulfillment of their ideals. The Declaration of Independence of 1776 stated that "all men are born equal."

By 1777 nearly all the colonies had a written constitution. These constitutions protected individual rights, freedom of press and freedom of religion. The Continental Congress had drafted the Articles of Confederation. The Church and the State were separated. Thomas Jefferson in his Virginia Statute for Religious Freedom introduced freedom of religion. It was later incorporated into the American Constitution.



Lafayette

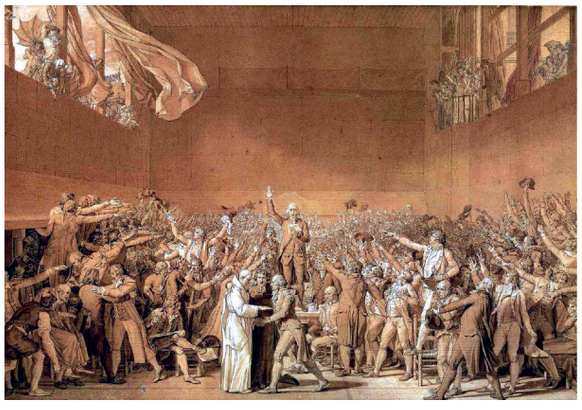
Lafayette, who fought the British on Washington's side through to the conclusive battle at Yorktown in 1781, later during the French Revolution served the French National Guard as its Commander. He penned the Declaration of the Rights of Man and the Citizen, with the help of Jefferson, which the National Assembly of France adopted on August 27, 1789.

II

9.2 The French Revolution

Introduction

The French Revolution exploded in 1789. The French monarchy of the *ancien regime* (political and social system that prevailed in France before the Revolution of 1789) had enjoyed unchallenged power for 140 years. Louis XIV and his great palace at Versailles had symbolized royal absolutism and the greatness of France. Yet, in the summer of 1789, that power suddenly begun to shake. Louis XVI had summoned the Estates General in May 1789. This body consisted of the representatives of three classes or "estates," as they were called: the clergy (men and women ordained for religious duties), the nobles and the commons (comprising lawyers, rich merchants, bankers and businessmen and wealthy landowners). But the representatives of the third estate, namely the commons had refused either to bow to the nobles or to obey the orders of the King.



Tennis Court Oath

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